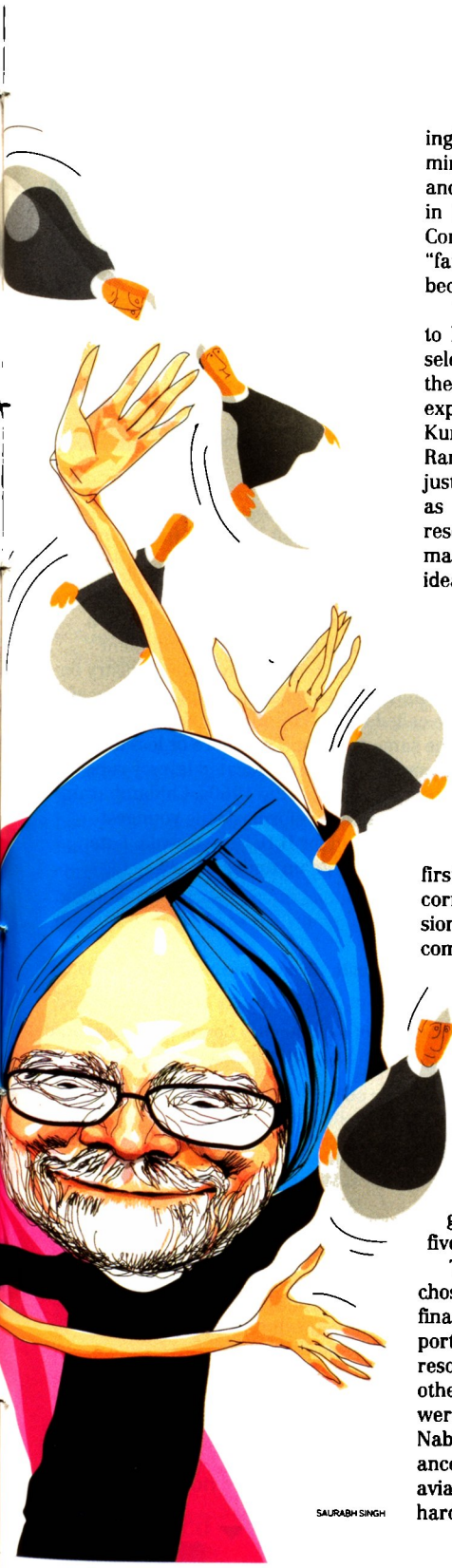




ingly, Veerappa Moily, a former chief minister of Karnataka, was given law and justice. His qualification: a degree in law. Understandably, some saner Congressmen were wondering how "failed" chief ministers could qualify to become Union ministers.

The politics of social justice seemed to have played a greater role in the selection. Or was it a manifestation of the fear of Mayawati? What else could explain the sudden elevation of Meira Kumar, daughter of the late Jagjivan Ram, as Lok Sabha Speaker? She was just coming to terms with her new job as the Union minister for water resources when the Congress high command found out that she was the most ideal candidate to become the country's

thought that Hans Raj Bhardwaj, a Rajya Sabha MP for 30 years and a trusted advocate of three generations of the Gandhis, would be dropped and replaced by Moily. Moily, a confidant of the former prime minister P.V. Narasimha Rao, was involved in the JMM bribery case. He was investigated for raising funds and bringing them to Delhi, though he was later acquitted. A team for change requires an action plan for the future. In the absence of a Common Minimum Programme, each one of them is busy blowing his own trumpet. Even as the Cabinet Secretariat was getting ready to circulate the Congress manifesto to all the ministries as the bible for future actions, most of the allies were busy

DALITS WERE ASKED TO DEAL WITH SOCIAL EMPOWERMENT AND TRIBALS WERE TOLD TO TAKE CARE OF TRIBALS. ARE THEY NOT GOOD FOR ANYTHING ELSE?

first woman Speaker. It was social correctness plus political condescension at work when leaders from certain communities were given the portfolios that were "suitable" to them. It was also the institutionalisation of a stereotype. Kumari Selja, a Dalit from Haryana, was asked to promote tourism as well as alleviate poverty. Muslims were given minority affairs, Dalits were asked to deal with social empowerment and the tribals were told to take care of tribals. Are they not good for anything else? There are five Dalits and a tribal in the Cabinet.

The prime minister undoubtedly chose the best for ministries like home, finance, external affairs, surface transport, rural development and human resource development, but there were others with good track records who were given lesser portfolios. Ghulam Nabi Azad, despite his stellar performance in parliamentary affairs and civil aviation, was given health. There was hardly anyone in the Congress who

formulating their own agendas.

Still, the biggest future task of this Cabinet is spelt Rahul. There are of course performers Manmohan can count on: P. Chidambaram, Pranab Mukherjee, Kamal Nath, A. Raja, Sharad Pawar, Anand Sharma and Kapil Sibal, if their past is any guide. However, those in charge of crucial sectors like health, mines, chemical and fertilisers, labour, law and justice, defence and urban development give little hope. In five years, the dutiful doctor has to show that he is worthy of the faith both Sonia and Rahul Gandhi (who refused to join the Cabinet) have reposed in him. If the coronation of a Gandhi happens in 2014, it will be after a gap of 25 years—and it'll also mark a historic hat-trick for the Congress. It will be a commoner premier's greatest parting gift if he succeeds in restoring the powers of India's unofficial monarchy that is the House of Gandhis. Manmohan and his unwieldy 77 have their work cut out for them.

SAURABH SINGH